

FREE LEAD MAGNET • THE SKILL MILL

The Honest Van Life Starter Budget

Year 1 costs at a glance — upfront build, monthly running costs, and the hidden fees nobody mentions.

If the romantic YouTube videos never give you a real number, this workbook does. Print it. Fill it in. Bring it to your partner.

Why bother tracking van life expenses?

Most people who give up on van life don't fail because of the van. They fail because the money math caught up with them in month 7 — a cracked windshield, a propane refill, a hotel night when it was 18°F and nothing worked. A realistic budget isn't pessimism. It's the thing that keeps you on the road.

This workbook gives you three things: a monthly budget template, a fuel log you can keep in the glove box, and a quick-reference for what van life actually costs at the Lean, Comfortable, and Nomad Pro tiers. Numbers come from *Van Life for Beginners* (Open Road Publishing) and from real nomads tracking expenses in 2025-26.

The three questions this workbook answers

1. What does it actually cost to build out a used Transit / Promaster / Sprinter?
2. What should I expect every month once I'm on the road?
3. Where do the "surprise" bills come from — and how do I forecast them?

How to use this PDF

- Print pages 3 and 4 double-sided — that's your working budget sheet.
- Fill in page 3 **before** you buy a van. Do it again after you've owned it for 90 days.
- Keep page 4 (fuel log) clipped to your visor. One line per fill-up. It pays for itself.
- Compare your numbers to the quick-reference on page 5 to sanity-check whether you're tracking Lean, Comfortable, or Nomad Pro.

Monthly Budget Template

Fill this in once at the start of each month. At the end of the month, circle anything that was **25%+ over** your estimate — those are the categories to optimize first.

Category	Budget (\$)	Actual (\$)	Variance	Notes
Fuel (miles / MPG / \$/gal)				
Converted-van insurance				
Phone + hotspot data plan				
Campgrounds / paid stays				
BLM / dispersed / free stays	0			
Groceries				
Restaurants / coffee				
Propane refills				
Laundromat				
Gym membership (showers)				
Maintenance reserve (\$/mi)				
Mail forwarding service				
Health insurance				
Domicile registration / tags				
Streaming + subscriptions				
Emergency / medical / vet				
Misc (gear, repairs, gifts)				
TOTAL				

Hidden costs nobody mentions

Mail forwarding — \$15-\$30/mo (Traveling Mailbox, Escapees).

Domicile state registration + vehicle tags — annual, but averages ~\$20-\$45/mo.

Health insurance when you leave your employer — \$300-\$600/mo plans common on marketplace.

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Propane refills — \$20-\$40 every 3-6 weeks for a Mr. Buddy / Wave heater rig.

Laundromat — \$15-\$30 per visit, ~twice a month.

Emergency vet or urgent-care visit — budget a \$100/mo sinking fund.

Fuel Log (clip to your visor)

One line per fill-up. After 10 fill-ups you'll know your real MPG — which is the single most-important number for forecasting the next month's fuel budget.

Date	Odometer	Gallons	\$ Total	\$/gal	Miles since last	MPG	Notes

Quick MPG math

MPG = (miles since last fill-up) ÷ (gallons this fill-up).

Average your last 10 fill-ups for a realistic number. One highway run is a lie.

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Monthly fuel = (expected miles / avg MPG) × current \$/gallon. Round up.

Converted vans lose 1-3 MPG vs. empty shell. Factor it.

Typical Van Life Monthly Cost — Quick Reference

Three tiers. Your real life is probably in between. Use this as a sanity check, not a target.

Category	Lean (≈\$1,500)	Comfortable (≈\$2,500)	Nomad Pro (\$4,000+)
Fuel	\$180-\$260	\$300-\$450	\$500-\$800
Insurance	\$80-\$120	\$110-\$170	\$150-\$250
Phone + data	\$50	\$90-\$120	\$140-\$200
Campgrounds / stays	\$0-\$60 (mostly free)	\$150-\$300	\$400-\$700
Groceries + food	\$300-\$400	\$450-\$650	\$700-\$900
Gym (showers)	\$20-\$40	\$40-\$60	\$60-\$100
Maintenance reserve	\$80	\$150	\$250+
Propane / utilities	\$30	\$40-\$60	\$60-\$80
Laundromat	\$25	\$40	\$50
Health insurance	\$0-\$300*	\$350-\$500	\$500-\$700
Subscriptions + misc	\$40	\$100	\$200
APPROX. TOTAL	\$1,300-\$1,700	\$2,200-\$2,800	\$3,700-\$4,500

* Lean assumes partner's plan, parent's plan, or a catastrophic-only marketplace plan. Don't skip this line; one ER visit without coverage has ended more van-life dreams than mechanical breakdowns have.

Upfront build cost ranges (one-time)

Used van (Transit/Promaster/Sprinter, 80-150k mi): \$18k - \$38k.

Insulation + floor + walls (DIY): \$600 - \$1,400.

Bed frame + storage (DIY plywood): \$250 - \$600.

Solar + battery + inverter (400W / 200Ah minimum viable): \$1,500 - \$3,000.

Water system (tank + pump + sink): \$150 - \$400.

Kitchen (induction / propane + 12V fridge): \$500 - \$1,200.

Contingency buffer: add 15% to your total and call it the truth.

Go from printable to powerful

This PDF gets you started. The editable spreadsheet is where the math does the work for you.

Van Life Budget Spreadsheet — on Etsy

Pre-built formulas for fuel cost, maintenance reserve, and break-even income. 12-month dashboard rolls up monthly sheets into a full Year-1 projection. Works in Google Sheets or Excel. Built from the same template used in this PDF.

Grab it here:

Want the whole playbook?

Van Life for Beginners (Open Road Publishing) is the full guide — vehicle selection, conversion plans, electrical + water sizing, stealth parking rules, and a deep chapter on Year-1 cost optimization.

One more thing

You got this PDF because you joined The Skill Mill email list. Here's what happens next — so you know the shape of it and can opt out any time.

- **Email #1 (today):** this PDF + a two-paragraph note from Howard on why van life budgets drift.
- **Email #2 (day 3):** the five things I wish I'd known before I bought my van.
- **Email #3 (day 7):** a deeper dive on stealth-parking rules by state.
- **After that:** one email per week, mostly new-chapter previews and the occasional reader Q&A.;

Questions, corrections, or stories from the road? Reply directly to any email. A real person reads them — that's part of the point. And the unsubscribe link is always at the bottom; no guilt trip, no survey.

Credits + disclosures

Data sources: *Van Life for Beginners* (Open Road Publishing, 2026); reader-submitted 2025-26 expense logs.

Nothing in this PDF is financial, legal, or medical advice — it's a budgeting worksheet. Talk to a pro before big purchases.

Numbers update annually. Pull the latest version any time at theskillmillbooks.com/van-life.